the hills and the outside world were down to the plains in the south and not in a northerly direction over the highest mountain range in the world. And, as noted earlier, if those tribals spoke any foreign language, it would have been broken Assamese rather than Tibetan—and definitely not Chinese.

But there is some confusion and obvious contradictions not only in the writings of Maxwell and Lamb, but also in those of many other Western scholars with regard to an Inner and an Outer Line, which they claim existed beside and below the McMahon Line. Some of what is written is true, but much is fiction and not only misunderstandings but also distortions of the actual situation along India's northern frontiers. Maxwell claims that there was a 'de facto borderline' where the 'broad plains of the Brahmaputra River begins to rise into the foothills of the Himalayas…The Raj called this accepted limit to its rule "the Outer Line" and prohibited unauthorised ingress or egress across it'.[61]

This is utter nonsense. In 1873, as a by-product of the Bengal Eastern Frontier Regulation, a law was implemented that created what was termed an Inner Line between the plains of Assam and its surrounding hill areas. However, the administration made it clear that 'this line does not necessarily indicate the territorial frontier but only the limits of the administered area…it does not in any way decide sovereignty of the territory beyond'.[62]

As Phanjoubam points out, 1873 was the time the cultivation of tea was expanding rapidly throughout Assam 'and speculators in tea were hungering for more land'.[63] Those speculators were encroaching into the hills and the lack of control over the communication between them and the rent-paying population meant that 'the government was losing out on substantial amounts of revenue'.[64] On the other hand, the Inner Line was deemed necessary to prevent what the colonial authorities called 'the wild tribes' from raiding the lowlands. Territories outside the Inner Line were under the 1919 Government of India Act categorized as 'excluded areas', 'partially excluded areas', and 'backward tracts'. But they were considered parts of British India, not some alien land.

The Inner Line Regulation is still in force in parts of northeastern India, and it also prevents people from the lowlands settling permanently north of the line. Indian citizens who are not from the northeastern hill states need special permits to enter Nagaland, Mizoram, Arunachal Pradesh, and